“Feeling angry is always a sin.”

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Where it often comes from

A home where anger was frightening, violent, or forbidden. Being punished for showing any frustration as a child. Church teaching that treated all anger as sinful. Seeing anger only expressed in harmful ways. Trying to be “nice” at all costs, then feeling guilty when anger builds anyway.

What Scripture teaches

Anger is an emotion God gave us, and it can be a right response to wrong. God Himself is slow to anger, but not without it. Jesus looked around with anger at hardness of heart. Scripture says, “Be angry, yet do not sin.” The question is not whether you feel anger, but what you do with it. Anger becomes sin when it is held onto, turns into bitterness, or is expressed in harmful ways.

> *“‘Be angry, yet do not sin.’ Do not let the sun set upon your anger, and do not give the devil a foothold”* **(Ephesians 4:26–27)**.

Also see

> “Jesus looked around at them with anger and sorrow at their hardness of heart. Then He said to the man, ‘Stretch out your hand.’ So he stretched it out, and it was restored” **(Mark 3:5)**.

> “Be angry, yet do not sin; on your bed, search your heart and be still” **(Psalm 4:4)**.

> “My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger, for man’s anger does not bring about the righteousness that God desires” **(James 1:19–20)**.

> “The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion” **(Psalm 103:8)**.

Common self-statements

- Good Christians never get angry.
- I’m sinning just by feeling this.
- I have to stuff my anger down.
- If I’m angry, God is angry with me.
- Anger always hurts people.
- I can’t admit I’m upset.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing anger is either completely absent or completely sinful.
- **Confusing feelings with actions:** Treating the feeling of anger as the same as acting in anger.
- **Should statements:** “I should never feel angry.”
- **Overgeneralization:** Assuming all anger is like the harmful anger you saw growing up.
- **Emotional suppression:** Pushing anger down until it comes out in other ways.

Challenging questions

- Did Jesus ever feel angry? Did He sin?
- What does “Be angry, yet do not sin” tell me?
- Is the problem the feeling, or what I do with it?
- Where did I learn that all anger is sinful?
- What happens when I stuff my anger instead of dealing with it?
- Is there a wrong here that anger is pointing me to?
- How can I express anger in a way that honors God?

Truth summary

> Feeling angry is not always a sin. Anger is a God-given emotion that can point to real wrongs. Jesus Himself was angry at hardness of heart. I can feel anger without sinning by admitting it, bringing it to God, dealing with it quickly, and expressing it in ways that do not harm others.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anger
- Communication
- Thinking, Healthy
- Forgive
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Feeling angry is always a sin"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Feeling angry is always a sin." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Did Jesus ever feel angry? Did He sin?
- ☐ What does "Be angry, yet do not sin" mean for me?
- ☐ Is the problem the feeling or what I do with it?
- ☐ Where did I learn all anger is sinful?
- ☐ What happens when I stuff my anger?
- ☐ What wrong is my anger pointing to?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Anger is a feeling, not automatically a sin.
- ☐ I can be angry and not sin.
- ☐ Jesus felt anger at what was wrong.
- ☐ I can bring my anger to God honestly.
- ☐ I can deal with anger quickly instead of storing it up.
- ☐ I can express anger without harming others.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Ephesians 4:26–27**
  "'Be angry, yet do not sin.' Do not let the sun set upon your anger, and do not give the devil a foothold."
- [ ] **Mark 3:5**
  "Jesus looked around at them with anger and sorrow at their hardness of heart. Then He said to the man, 'Stretch out your hand.' So he stretched it out, and it was restored."
- [ ] **Psalm 4:4**
  "Be angry, yet do not sin; on your bed, search your heart and be still."
- [ ] **James 1:19–20**
  "My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger, for man's anger does not bring about the righteousness that God desires."
- [ ] **Psalm 103:8**
  "The LORD is compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Anger log:** Each time I feel angry, write what happened, what wrong I saw, and one healthy way I handled it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 4:4 becomes: "**Sarah** can be angry, yet not sin; on **her** bed, **she** can search **her** heart and be still."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Anger" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Next time you feel angry, say calmly,** "I feel angry because ___," to yourself or a safe person, instead of hiding it.
- ☐ **Before bedtime, write down** anything you are angry about and pray about it, so the sun does not set on it.
- ☐ **Read Mark 3:1–6,** and write what Jesus was angry about and what He did with it.
- ☐ **Take a ten-minute walk** when anger rises, then decide what to say or do.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Feeling angry is always a sin": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One time I handled anger well
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Feeling angry is always a sin.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You for making me with the ability to feel anger at what is wrong. Help me reject the lie that feeling angry is always a sin. Teach me to be angry without sinning, to bring my anger to You, to deal with it quickly, and to express it in ways that honor You. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.